PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Toyota Land Cruiser Prado 90

1996–2002 · J90 · KZJ95 · VZJ95 · KDJ95

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Ask when the lower ball joints were done**
  Australia recalled a range of five-door Prados in May 2005 (PRA 2005/7749) because a scratched joint could wear and separate from the knuckle. AustralianCar.Reviews says joints still fail after the recall, and IH8MUD owners replace them preventively with genuine Toyota parts, because a joint can feel tight and still let go.

- [ ] **Diesel: hunt for signs of overheating**
  On the 1KZ-TE, overheating is how heads crack. Look for coolant bubbling into the overflow bottle, coolant loss or discoloration, and a gauge that climbs on hills or in traffic. Known causes include a tired viscous fan hub, a blocked radiator and a seized wastegate actuator. On a 260,000 km truck, one IH8MUD member's verdict was that 'the head on the 1kz has already been done', so ask for the receipt.

- [ ] **Check the ATF for coolant**
  The automatic's oil cooler sits inside the engine radiator, so a crack lets coolant into the transmission. Pink, milky fluid on the dipstick is a deal-breaker, or at least a new radiator and a transmission rebuild.

- [ ] **Rear axle flange recall (early trucks)**
  Prados built from 17 April 1996 to 6 January 1999 were recalled in Australia (PRA 2006/8499) because the rear axle-shaft flange could crack after repeated hard driving on winding roads, and in the worst case let the wheel come off. A Japanese import won't have the paperwork, so inspect the flanges.

- [ ] **Know which engine you're buying**
  The model code tells you: VZJ = 3.4 V6, RZJ = 2.7 four, KZJ = 1KZ-TE diesel, KDJ = 1KD-FTV diesel (July 2000 on, Japan). '90' is the three-door, '95' the five-door. The V6 has a timing belt, and the 2.7 a chain.

- [ ] **Timing belt history**
  HD Automotive gives the 1KZ-TE belt interval as 100,000 km or 5–6 years, and the 5VZ-FE V6 is a 90,000-mile belt. With no receipt, budget for the belt and water pump on day one.

- [ ] **Import paperwork**
  A US truck should come with proof that it was at least 25 years old on entry (the date runs from manufacture), the customs entry and the NHTSA HS-7 and EPA 3520-1 declarations. Check that your state will title and register it before you buy, especially California.

- [ ] **Test the sub tank and CV boots**
  On trucks with a sub tank, check that the switch-over works: AustralianCar.Reviews warns the mechanism can seize and the fuel go stale if it was never used. While you're underneath, look for split CV boots and grease on the inside of the front wheels.

YEARS TO KNOW

April 1997	BEWARE	2.7 L 3RZ-FE four added (150 PS). 4X4 Australia tells buyers to steer clear of the 2.7 unless they want to punish themselves

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **V6 fuel-tank solenoid valve (Australia)**
  V6 petrol · PRA 1997/3426
- ☐ **Front lower ball joints (Australia)**
  Five-door RZJ95, VZJ95, KZJ95 (VIN ranges listed) · PRA 2005/7749
- ☐ **Rear axle-shaft flange crack (Australia)**
  Built 17 April 1996 – 6 January 1999 · PRA 2006/8499

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **Model code = engine + body**
  VZJ = 3.4 V6, RZJ = 2.7 four, KZJ = 1KZ-TE diesel, KDJ = 1KD-FTV diesel. 90 is the three-door, 95 the five-door. Japanese codes carry a 'W' suffix (e.g. VZJ95W).
- ☐ **1KZ or 1KD?**
  Toyota fitted the common-rail 1KD-FTV from July 2000 in Japan, so a KDJ95 should be a mid-2000-or-later truck. 4X4 Australia lists the Australian J90 diesel as the 1KZ-TE, from March 2000.
- ☐ **Pre- or post-facelift**
  Trucks built after the June 1999 minor change have large multi-reflector headlights, clear-lens indicators and a revised grille and bumper. Five-doors grew from 4,675 mm to 4,690 mm.
- ☐ **Japanese grades**
  Japanese three-door grades start with R (RZ, RX) and five-door grades with T (TZ, TX, TX Limited). Australian five-doors were sold as RV, RV6, GXL and VX Grande.
- ☐ **Lockers**
  Every J90 has a center-diff lock. Australian trucks had no factory axle lockers, so an ad claiming 'factory lockers' needs proof.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/land-cruiser/prado-90/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks